LETTER FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Endings are the generous footnotes of new beginnings and therefore need to be celebrated. So before we call it a wrap for 2024, *Spice* toasts the highlights of the year that was. Since nothing clocks the passage of time better than a watch, it's only fitting that we begin from the rarefied reaches of the watch universe, where interesting collaborations dotted the calendar year.

Imagine the gilded tribute to a legendary smoke with a cigar maker and a luxury Swiss watch combining their crafts. Hublot's latest masterpiece, the Classic Fusion Chronograph Arturo Fuente King Gold is a glittering homage to the storied Fuente Fuente OpusX cigar on its silver anniversary. The 42mm timepiece, crafted in Hublot's proprietary 18-carat King Gold boasts a bezel adorned with engraved tobacco leaves in a playful nod to the verdant Dominican landscape, the birthing ground of these coveted cigars. Limited to just 50 pieces, it is housed in a lacquered humidor-style box.

While pop art inspired watch dials, bezels and straps make for pitch-perfect statement pieces, wearable stories from haute horology bet on the nostalgia of vintage. With the business of pre-owned watches booming, a number of luxury watch marques have started to offer certified pre-owned (CPO) timepieces alongside their new collections. The Morgan Stanley Luxeconsult watch industry report 2024, estimates the overall secondary watch market at US$25 billion, compared to an approximate US$ 60-80 billion for the primary market. While Rolex launched its certified pre-owned plan in late 2022, Vacheron Constantin launched its own CPO programme in November 2024, joining the ranks of Audemars Piguet, Cartier, F. P. Journe, MB&F, Richard Mille, and Urwerk among others.

While harking back to heritage is an old luxury favourite, when it comes to the vibrant world of mixology, a new chapter is being stirred by some incredible bar experiences, which showcase spectacular sips employing next generation bartending techniques, rare ingredients and dazzling presentations. The Bumipura in Mumbai offers laboratory-crafted drinks that are inspired by wholesome Malay and Singaporean food. Being shaken and stirred is par for the course when a martini is inspired by Hainanese chicken rice or offers a creative take on Malaysia's iconic Nasi Lemak with a foam made from jasmine rice cooked with coconut cream and pandan leaves.

Not to be outdone, restaurants have done their bit to raise the bar too. The *Spice* taste adventures summon some of the more interesting Asian curations of 2024. If Gauri Khan's Torii in Mumbai elevates the star quotient with its stunning design, Drunken Fish at Wynn Macau brings to the table the world's rarest and most premium seafood.

Whether it's great food, drink or fashion, it's the ability to rewrite the narrative that scores, which is why scintillating storytelling is key to capturing interest and imagination. Who knows that better than designer, beauty-business genius, and film-maker, Tom Ford, a man who manifests many lives. "I'm a storyteller. I think I did that through fashion, images, stores. But making films is the closest you ever get to being God. Because you're not just designing clothes. You're designing what they do, what they say. And it's forever sealed in a bubble," he says.

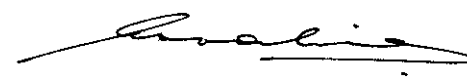
On the silver screen, as in reality, whatever your cult status or performance, it's the next chapter that keeps you relevant. Much like the AMG version of Mercedes-Benz's legendary G-Class SUV.

Here's to reimagining the future in 2025!





● **Cocktail inspired by** the Purana Qila at Cirrus 9, The Oberoi, New Delhi (Above); Athens Riviera is the new hotspot



(Aroon Purie)